Evolution of China's Cooperation with the BRICS Group

In October 2007, at the 17th National Congress of the CPC, Hu Jintao mentioned that ‘China cannot develop in isolation from the rest of the world.’ Otherwise, the world would not enjoy the prosperity and stability of China's presence. At the same 17th National Congress of the CPC meeting, Jintao expounded that tremendous changes and adjustments were happening within present international relations, propelling even closer interconnections between China's future and destiny (Hu 2007).[13] The Chinese leaders soon regarded how China, together with other like-minded countries, could construct a just and rational global order. China became a regional and inter-regional organization member to maintain friendships with other nations instead of engaging in conflicts. There is an old stratagem in China that succinctly defines the situation. ‘Making friends avoid war keeps the enemy wondering!’ (Dmitry 2015).

That resulted from cooperating and taking membership in groups like SCO and BRICS. It was then that Chinese foreign policy strategy shifted toward alternative markets. Liu Junhong (2009) stated that a financial emergency originated from a US-devastated world economy, including BRIC members. However, BRIC countries overcame this crisis earlier than the West did. Thus, four countries’ stock markets rebounded by 40–70 percent between February and early June, creating hope for the global economy. While briefing the Media before the first BRIC summit, Chinese vice foreign minister He Yafei on June 9, 2009, expressed that China was expecting BRIC to expand strategic consensus and consolidate mutual trust among group members. This Summit would provide the scope for coping with the global financial and economic crisis and pave the way for a future development agenda (Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China 2009).[14] Furthermore, a scholar like Qin Zhilai (2009)[15] termed the BRIC formation as ‘non-confrontational toward existing international institutions.

However, China's cooperation in the BRICS resulted from innovation in Chinese diplomatic theory and its practice in the post-Cold War period. China faced the changes that have been happening in the international system since 1990. In the process, China proposed a series of diplomatic ideas, which included establishing a democratic world order that was fair and reasonable, a concept of multipolarity, an emphasis on being a responsible